

Chapter 108_1 - Flower Stem

The turmoil at the immortal gates spread back to the demon realm, causing the demon race to live in constant fear. Some demon clan leaders who had previously been defeated by Ning Fuyi came one after another to the demon cave to pay their respects, but were all told that the Demon Venerable was occupied with important matters and could not see them, so they could only leave dejectedly.

Within the heavily guarded demon cave, ten thousand zhang¹ of pink light filled the barrier, completely at odds with the gloomy darkness overhead.

Several people waited anxiously outside the door, pacing back and forth. Hancrow was so anxious she pulled out several hairs from her head, grabbing Jiuying who was eating preserved plums: "I say, Lord Qilin, our Demon Venerable has been inside for three whole days, and her life or death is unknown. Think of something!"

Jiuying was pulled until her shoulders went askew. She snatched her clothes back from Hancrow's hands to cover her fragrant shoulders, rolled her eyes and said: "Your Demon Venerable is breaking through a bottleneck, not laying eggs. What life or death could there be?"

Xique also said: "But what if she goes astray in cultivation? I heard that whenever cultivators break through, they undergo tribulation. The slightest carelessness could cause immortal energy to flow backward, bursting the immortal meridians. If..."

"If what?" Jiuying said helplessly, "Look at her immortal energy - it's clear and even, without any disturbance. How does this look like someone who's gone astray in cultivation?"

"If she truly went astray, there should be frequent anomalies and chaotic immortal energy."

However, as soon as she finished speaking, a tremendous roar came from within the pink light, followed by rolling thunder and crisscrossing lightning.

Jiuying: ...

She quickly threw down the bag of preserved plums in her hand and flashed to the front of the demon hall door, reaching out to undo the barrier. However, the barrier was like a sealed wall - the moment her fingertips touched it, she was electrocuted and staggered back repeatedly.

"Damn it." Jiuying cursed under her breath. She waved away Hancrow and Xique who came forward to help, quickly formed hand seals with both hands, and a narrow red mark lit up between her eyebrows.

Red light emerged from the red mark, like a sharp blade tearing open the barrier. Then overwhelming power rushed out from the gap, like a flood that had been suppressed for thousands of years bursting through a dam, quickly collapsing the barrier. The surroundings of the demon realm were suddenly filled with rolling rocks and crumbling mountains.

The entire demon cave was eroded by the storm. Though the demons in the cave had long known the Demon Venerable was cultivating, they were still frightened into running around with their heads covered, not daring to approach the demon hall even an inch.

The demon hall, originally like a sharp sword piercing the night sky, also swayed precariously, but fortunately it had been reinforced by Ning Fuyi, so it only swayed precariously.

Jiuying quickly transformed into wind and squeezed into the barrier, nearly being knocked head over heels by the fierce wind. She had to transform into a qilin², using her four hooves to dig into the ground to stabilize herself. She saw that the spacious hall had long been filled with dazzling light, and the fierce wind had swept away all the furnishings in the hall, even grinding the stone tables to powder.

"Ning Fuyi!" Seeing this, Jiuying sat down with a thump and used the natural pure energy of divine beasts to protect her. Only then did the fierce wind weaken somewhat, and the trembling of the demon hall became gentler.

The light faded, and the figure in the center of the hall finally appeared. The black clothes on the woman's body had been almost completely torn apart by the wind swirling around her, leaving only silk threads fluttering in the wind, though still covering her body.

Her jade-white arms were exposed, with a string of bronze bells hanging on them, making crisp continuous sounds in the wind.

After an unknown amount of time, the bell sounds gradually weakened, the hall became quiet, and her hair, no longer entangled by the wind, finally fell softly, hanging between her smooth collarbones.

Ning Fuyi opened her eyes. Her eyes, originally flowing with brilliant colors, gradually returned to their usual deep color, yet seemed deeper than before - so deep they couldn't reflect the mottled light before her.

Great Vehicle Realm, middle stage. After years of bottleneck, she had actually advanced two levels at once, directly reaching the middle stage.

Only then did Jiuying transform back into human form. She looked at Ning Fuyi reproachfully and stood up supporting her knees: "No wonder you had trouble breaking through the bottleneck - breaking through once seems like it would kill you."

Ning Fuyi was still not quite accustomed to it. When she raised her hand, she suddenly had the illusion that even the finest dust before her eyes rose with her gesture. She closed her eyes again and lowered her palm, and her divine consciousness immediately passed through the hall door to envelop the demon cave, extending toward the jagged rocks hundreds of li³ away.

Her palm fell to her knee, and those rocks beneath the sky trembled slightly.

She traced back to her sea of consciousness again, surprised to discover that the tree with bright red fruit had quietly disappeared, leaving only the black tree on the slope, motionless.

"So your previous bottleneck was because of your mother?" Jiuying patted her dress and asked.

"From how it looks now, it should be." Ning Fuyi withdrew her divine consciousness from her sea of consciousness. She still felt somewhat dazed by the sensation of perceiving all things.

All things arise from the heart. She had always felt guilty toward Ning Changfeng and felt inferior about not being a genius, which had harmed Ning Changfeng who cut her own immortal energy, went astray in cultivation and died. Over time, this became a heart knot, so even though immortal energy was in her body, she couldn't advance another level.

But now, after wandering the mortal world, she had unexpectedly encountered Ning Changfeng again. Though that person was only a reincarnation of Ning Changfeng and was no longer Ning Changfeng herself, those few brief words had already untied her heart knot.

Ning Changfeng would not regret it, so she would not regret it for Ning Changfeng either.

She would become even stronger than the person Ning Changfeng had spoken of.

"I always used to think, why did all this have to happen to me, when I'm just an ordinary person? I don't have Chu Qingqiu's god-like origins, I don't have Liu Wenzhu's talent, I don't even have your ancient bloodline, Jiuying." Ning Fuyi didn't mind her tattered state and spoke.

Jiuying listened while sweeping up the mess on the ground, then sat beside her.

Even in her previous life, she had cultivated the demonic path because of that ancient evil spirit's curse and the demon root it left behind, living in confusion for a lifetime, knowing nothing.

Jiuying was silent for a moment, then suddenly patted her shoulder: "Do you know why I was willing to abandon my freedom and stay by your side as your divine beast?"

"Because that time in the tiger's den, I saw you take your friend's place under the fierce fire, just to exchange for her life. Also because before Penglai, you never abandoned me twice, and though I am your divine beast, you never once made me stand in front of you."

"There are many geniuses in this world, but genuine hearts are few and far between. Staying by your side makes one feel very safe. I won't worry about you trampling me into the abyss like Chidu⁴ did, but can walk shoulder to shoulder with you."

Ning Fuyi smiled. She exhaled and raised her hand, already changed into different clothes - black garments embroidered with gold threads spread out in layers, more magnificent than before. Her black hair was bound high with golden ornaments, complementing her deep eyebrows and eyes.

"Before I broke through, I think I heard that Shangchou wanted to report something?" Ning Fuyi suddenly remembered something from three days ago. At that time, she was eager to break through, so she had blocked him outside, only remembering now.

Jiuying's eyes turned as she recalled for a moment, then clapped her hands: "Oh right, there have been many important matters these past few days. You really chose a bad time to break through."

She then pulled out several red leather-bound books from her sleeve, all containing important matters presented in recent days, and handed them all to Ning Fuyi.

"This one is about Divine Venerable Yan's⁵ resurrection. I suppose you don't want to see this one, so let's skip it." Jiuying pulled the book back from Ning Fuyi's hands and placed it behind herself.

Ning Fuyi's hand paused but she didn't object.

"This one says our people mistakenly captured an underworld judge a few days ago. At the time, Shangchou mistook him for someone from the immortal gates and threw him into the Black Water River⁶, asking how to deal with him." Jiuying pursed her lips. "Now that he's been imprisoned for several days, I don't know if he's still alive."

"An underworld judge - how did they mistake him for someone from the immortal gates?" Ning Fuyi felt somewhat helpless.

She vaguely remembered the judge from when she and Chu Qingqiu went to the underworld - even "green-faced and fang-toothed" could hardly describe how terrifying he was.

Jiuying shook her head, equally puzzled, then took out the last book. Her expression became more serious - this book bore the character "Caution" on it, clearly indicating important matters.

"Do you still remember what I told you in the mortal world about Penglai saying they would present something at the demon-slaying conference that could subdue you? Now the demon-slaying conference will be held in early spring of the third month on Liugen Huayan Island⁷, widely summoning cultivators from all immortal gates to attend."

"What medicine is Penglai selling in their gourd⁸?" Jiuying asked.

Ning Fuyi placed her hand on her knee, gently tapping, then suddenly asked: "Will all the immortal gates attend? Will Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate go too?"

Jiuying nodded.

Ning Fuyi smiled. She handed the book back to Jiuying and said: "Then I'm rather looking forward to seeing what expressions those immortal gates will have when they see me."

Jiuying suddenly stood up upon hearing this: "Penglai clearly has no good intentions. You're not really planning to walk into their trap, are you?"

"Of course I know they have no good intentions, but I don't have good intentions either." Ning Fuyi's smile bloomed. "I've been hiding for thirty years. Now it's time for them to live in fear and trepidation too."

"Penglai has tried every means to make me appear. I want to see who loses their composure first."

After saying this, Ning Fuyi stood up and stretched lazily. The prayer bead⁹ on her wrist slid down from the top, hanging at her forearm.

This reminded her of another matter. She took out a glazed bottle from the prayer bead and handed it to Jiuying. The pearls inside flowed with brilliant light, rolling like water.

"If I remember correctly, by this time, that merman should have been freed from guilt, had his memory reshaped, and been taken back to Penglai, right?"

Jiuying nodded.

"Please help me return his memory to him." Ning Fuyi twisted her fingers and took small steps forward. "And please add these words: 'Congratulations on your new life.'"

"Fine." Jiuying drawled, reluctantly agreeing, raising her chin: "You've given me all the work. What are you going to do?"

"Look for Chu Qingqiu?" Jiuying tilted her head slightly teasingly. "You're not going to covet beauty again, are you?"

Ning Fuyi's footsteps came to an abrupt halt, then she said half-seriously, half-jokingly: "I've nurtured her body and protected her for a lifetime. I've already done my utmost."

"She blocked me from her heart twice back then. I don't have such thick skin. From now on, I will never seek her out again."

These words carried some anger. Ning Fuyi put down her fingers and clasped them behind her back: "I'm going to the Black Water River to borrow that judge."

Footnotes:

- ¹ **Zhang (丈)** - A traditional Chinese unit of measurement, approximately 3.33 meters or 10.9 feet
- ² **Qilin (麒麟)** - A mythical Chinese creature, often called a Chinese unicorn, symbolizing prosperity and serenity
- ³ **Li (里)** - A traditional Chinese unit of distance, approximately 500 meters or 0.31 miles
- ⁴ **Chidu (赤都)** - A character from the story's past, mentioned as someone who betrayed Jiuying
- ⁵ **Divine Venerable Yan (言神尊)** - A character whose resurrection is mentioned but details are skipped
- ⁶ **Black Water River (黑水河)** - A location in the demon realm used for imprisonment
- ⁷ **Liugen Huayan Island (六根华严岛)** - The location where the demon-slaying conference will be held
- ⁸ **What medicine is selling in their gourd** - A Chinese idiom meaning "what are their true intentions" or "what are they really planning"
- ⁹ **Prayer bead (一念珠)** - A magical storage device that can contain items within it